the desire to maintain autonomy often lead to a reluctance to describe India as an American ally, preferring to use the phrase ‘strategic partner’.

Even today, when the world is no longer aligned the way it was during the cold war, India still remains a prominent member of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) and often uses that platform to demonstrate its independence from great powers. The anomaly led former Indian prime minister Inder Kumar Gujral to remark, ‘It is a mantra that we have to keep repeating, but who are you going to be non-aligned against?’[9]

Over the years, the desire for decision-making autonomy that led to non-alignment has tied into the concomitant goal of ensuring India’s territorial integrity and unity. As a country that was colonized piecemeal by a distant power that initially sought trading privileges, India has been vigilant about safeguarding its territory against foreign encroachment. The legacy of Partition reinforced the need for unity and cohesion lest the country be again divided in the name of religion or ethnicity. Independent India has consistently sought an international environment that would guarantee its independence, safeguard its territory, help build its economy, bolster its military resources and ensure domestic stability and social cohesion. A peaceful and stable global environment is seen as the precondition for India’s development and evolution in pursuit of its historic place under the sun.

India’s decision to stay away from military alliances and follow a path of non-alignment stems from the view that this path would ensure independence in decision making. While other newly independent countries opted to seek benefits of alignment with one or the other superpower, India chose to stay out of the cold war. India did not have the resources to participate in such a conflict, did not consider the inducements of aid and weapons offered by the superpowers as worth their price and feared that cold war alignment could tear its fragile nation apart.